Minimum Viable Product (MVP) Plan

Purpose: Turn the findings in the separate Research & User Persona document into a focused, testable MVP. Use the research document as the source of truth for survey responses, user personas, journey maps, and research insights.

1. Product Decision Brief

Complete this section after reviewing the research findings. Keep the focus on the product decision and the value to be tested—not on redoing user research.

Validated opportunity: Which research-backed opportunity are we choosing to address? Reference the insight or persona/journey-map finding.

Based on our research, students' biggest pains happen before the hangout, specifically changing availability, deciding what to do, and splitting costs, and everyone on our final form only plans in group chats. During the hangout they also repeat the same manual actions on every phone (sharing location, AirDropping photos, connecting a speaker), but our research doesn't back that pain as strongly yet since nobody listed device setup as a top pain. That's why Spaces starts at the planning stage and carries through the hangout. This matches the Social Coordinator persona's frustrations and the First Use and After Use stages of the journey map.

MVP objective: What specific outcome should this first version deliver?

A friend group should be able to plan and run a hangout from one temporary space that starts in the group chat, so availability, the plan, and the cost split are handled in one place for everyone who joins, with one tap and no setup per phone.

Proposed solution: In one or two sentences, what are we proposing to build or test?

We want to design a "space" that students can start directly from a group chat for one hangout. It starts at the planning stage: friends join with one tap, pick the times that work, and see one live plan. For the length of the hangout, their iPhones and one shared Apple TV share the plan, who's coming, and the cost split, with location being an optional toggle that defaults to off. Then, everything turns off automatically when the space ends.

Isn't this just Apple Invites? Invites already does RSVPs, shared albums, and playlists, but an invite is static, it's a page you send once and check. Spaces is live, the plan updates as people's availability changes, and it actually changes how everyone's devices behave during the hangout (Live Activity, the shared Apple TV, and sharing that turns off by itself when it ends).

Value hypothesis: If we provide [capability] to [target user], we expect [measurable improvement] because [research evidence].

If we provide a one tap temporary space that handles availability, the plan, and the cost split across a friend group's iPhones and one shared Apple TV to socially active undergrads who

mostly use iPhones, we expect friend groups to start another space within 30 days and manual coordination steps to drop from 3-4 to 1, because everyone in our research plans only through group chats and splits costs by hand through other apps.

Business value: Spaces is about keeping people in the Apple ecosystem, not selling new iPhones. It makes the Apple devices a friend group already has more useful together, and gives a reason to buy a shared accessory like an Apple TV or HomePod for an apartment or dorm. Android friends get a limited web view (see the plan, pick times, see the cost split) so it doesn't feel exclusionary.

Key assumption to test: What must be true for this solution to be useful, feasible, and adopted?

- In order to be useful, Spaces has to fix the pains students actually told us about, which are changing availability, deciding what to do, and splitting costs. The during-hangout part is shakier because, based on our research, nobody listed "device setup" as a top pain point, so we're running a few follow-up interviews to check it
- To be feasible, syncing states needs to work across devices for the length of a hangout, and it also cannot drain the battery life or fire notifications constantly
- To be adopted, enough of each friend group needs to have an iPhone to make a space worth starting, and students need to be able to share location when it's scoped to one hangout, and Android friends need to be able to follow along from a web link without feeling left out

2. MVP Scope and Boundaries

Define the smallest end-to-end experience that delivers the intended value. User characteristics and pain points belong in the Research & User Persona document; here, reference them only when they justify a scope decision.

Primary user / use case: Name the target segment or persona and cite the relevant research finding; do not recreate the persona.

- Maya (Social Coordinator) wants a hangout with her friends. The persona shows she plans with group chats but wants more coordination. Jordan (Lowkey Joiner) also participates, but wants an easy, private joining experience.

Core user journey: List the minimum steps from starting the task to receiving the core benefit.

- The person in charge of planning opens or makes a group chat, hits Share Space.
- The organizer adds a name, a place, and 2-3 time options.
- Group members get an invite card in the chat, join with one tap, and pick the times that work; Android friends get a web link with a limited view.
- Members can see the hangout page and choose what they want to share.
- Members check the details when they need to, so they don't have to ask for time or location multiple times.

- Space expires after the end, temporary sharing stops, and members are asked what they want to keep.

MVP capabilities: List only capabilities required to complete that journey.

- Create and invite people to a space from a group chat.
- One-tap accept/join from a link or prompt.
- Shared space page that shows who joined, times, meeting locations, and attendance status.
- Toggles for giving location, defaults to off
- Can see an end time; the organizer can stop it.
- Availability picker on the invite card that updates the plan for everyone when times change.
- Shared cost split that everyone in the space can see and pay back from.
- Limited web view for Android friends (see the plan, pick times, see the cost split).

Out of scope: List features, platforms, integrations, and edge cases deliberately deferred.

- Anything low priority in the prioritization matrix
- Devices besides iPhone and one shared Apple TV (Mac, iPad, Apple Watch, AirPods, HomePod)
- Other space types like persistent dorm or party spaces, we're only building the temporary hangout space
- A full Android app, Android friends only get the web view
- Building out more than the one flow we'll demo (start, invite, join, end)

3. Feature Prioritization Matrix

Classify each candidate capability once. Prioritize by contribution to the core user value, necessity for an end-to-end test, risk reduction, and implementation effort. Use research evidence to justify decisions; do not repeat survey questions, persona details, or journey-map content. (add rows as needed)

Priority	Decision rule	Candidate feature/capability	Evidence or rationale	Owner/status
MUST HAVE	Required for the core journey to work or for the MVP to test its main	Shared space page that shows meeting times/attendance status	The majority of users surveyed found that changing availability was hardest to manage when planning a hangout and	Engineering Lead/ Tech Lead

	value hypothesis.	and allows for managing costs	that splitting costs/sending payments have to be done manually	
MUST HAVE	Required for safety, privacy, reliability, or a critical dependency.	Location sharing defaults to off, and all sharing turns off automatically when the space ends	People are split on sharing their location even for a short time, and sharing that turns off by itself was a must have in our research insights	Engineering Lead/ Tech Lead
NICE TO HAVE	Improves usability or value, but the MVP can still deliver and validate its core promise without it.	Shared space allows for photo/video and music sharing on everyone's phones and the shared Apple TV	There isn't much of a perceived need from users, but it may allow for an experience with less friction in the long run. We'll check this in the follow-up interviews	Engineering Lead/ Tech Lead
LOW PRIORITY	Polish, advanced options, secondary use cases, or features that can wait until after initial validation.	Shared space is aesthetically appealing and includes modern design elements, plus templates/pre-sets for other kinds of hangouts	There isn't a need for the MVP to look polished in its early stages and can be worked on after the core functionality is solidified. We're only testing one temporary hangout space first, so templates can wait	Design/UX Lead

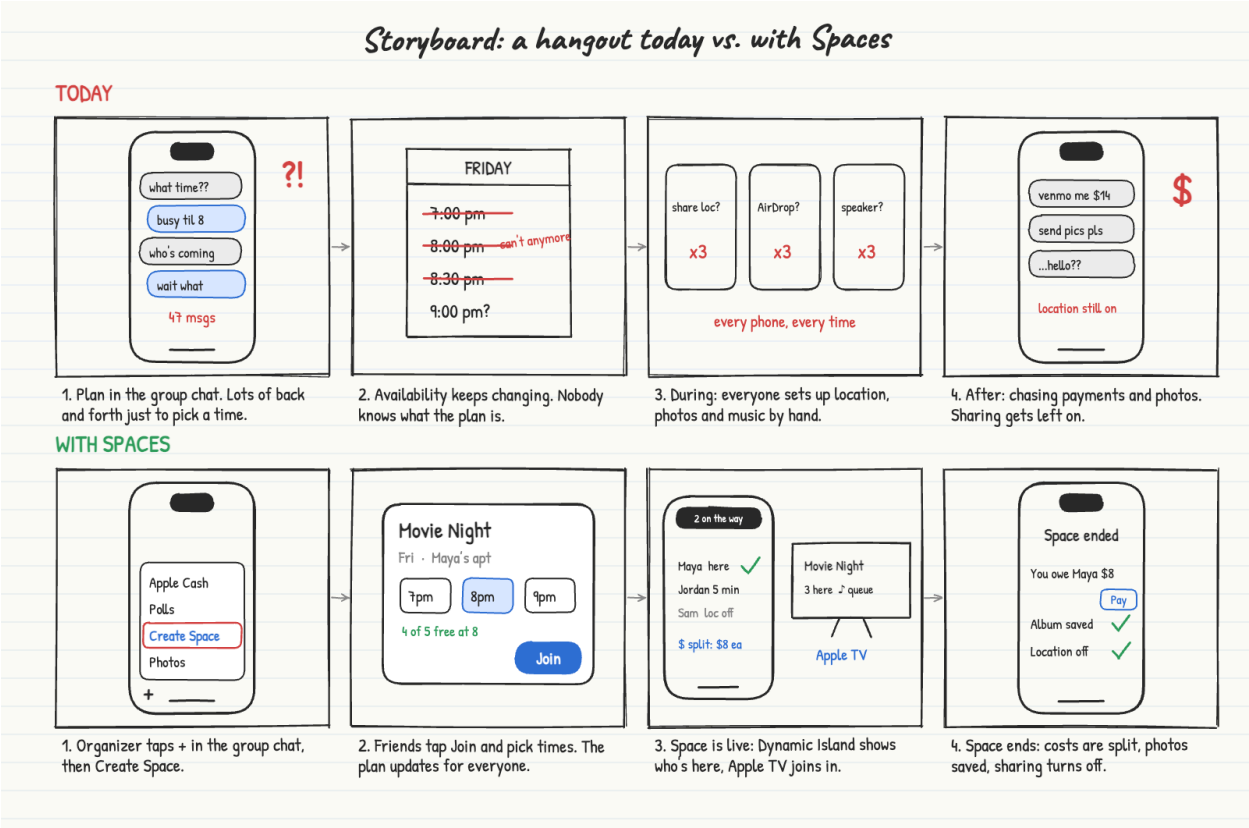
Prioritization check:

- Every **MUST HAVE** directly supports the core journey, a critical dependency, or a non-negotiable risk requirement.
- **NICE TO HAVE** items are not launch blockers and can be deferred if time or resources are constrained.
- **LOW PRIORITY** items are explicitly deferred unless new evidence changes their value.
- No item is listed in more than one priority category.

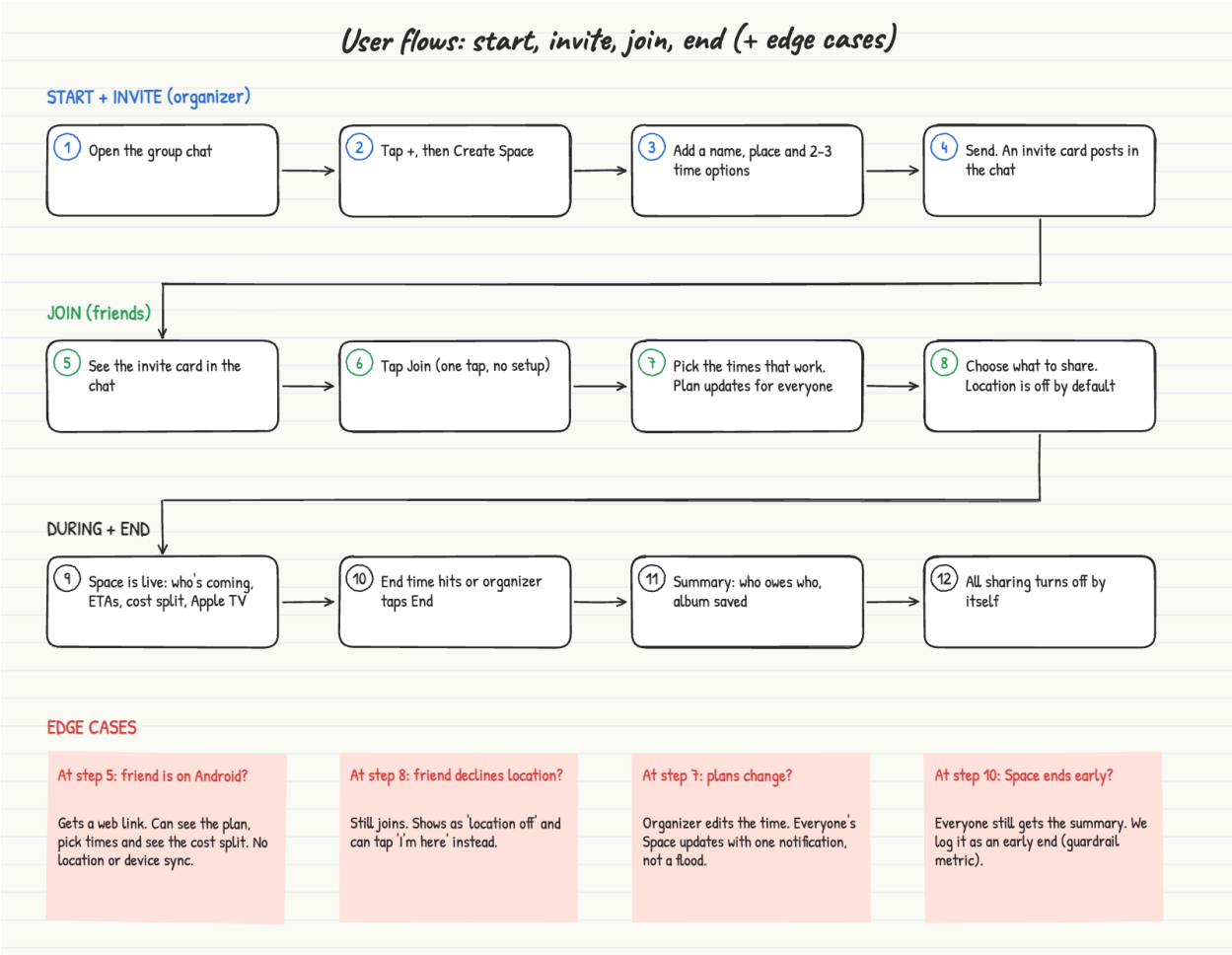
4. Sketches

Following the feedback, we started with storyboards of a hangout today vs. with Spaces, then mapped the user flows for start, invite, join and end, including edge cases. After that we sketched a few ideas for where Spaces should live, the core screens on paper, and one ecosystem map of what each device does when a space starts. Our first mockup (Create Space in the Messages + menu) is in the brainstorm/sketches tab.

Storyboard: today, all of the work is manual and happens in the group chat. With Spaces, planning, the hangout and the cleanup happen in one place.



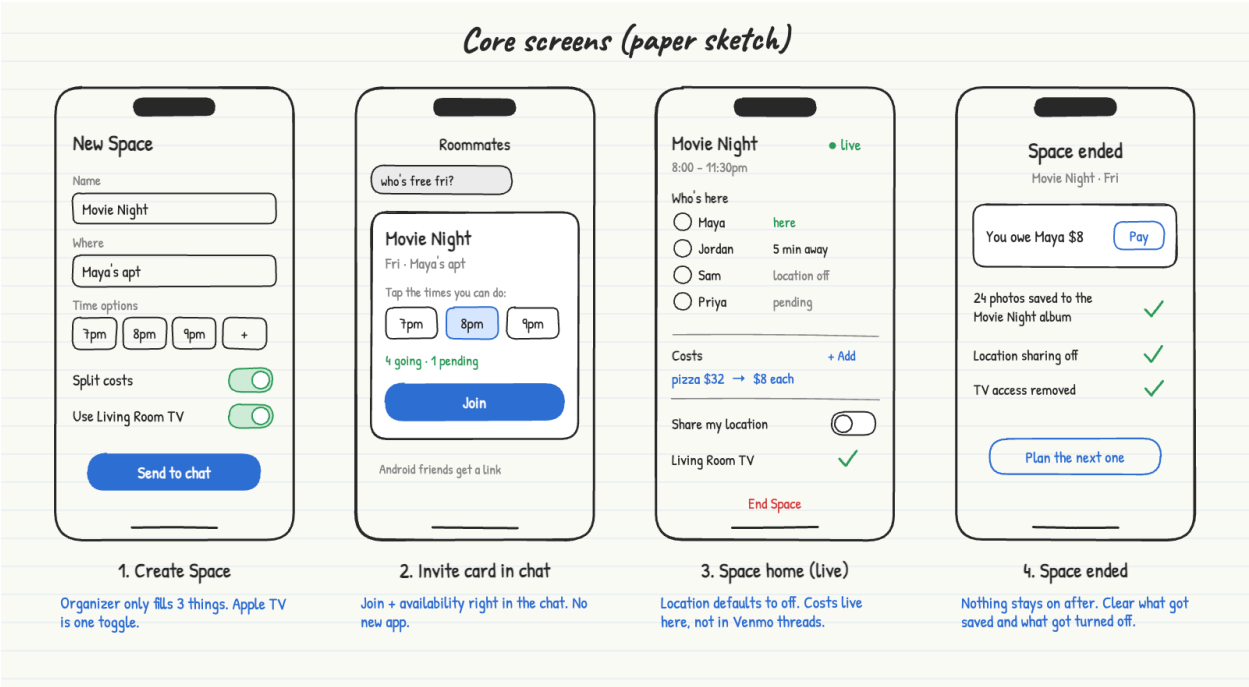
User flows + edge cases: the edge cases we designed for are a friend on Android, a friend who declines location, plans changing, and a space ending early.



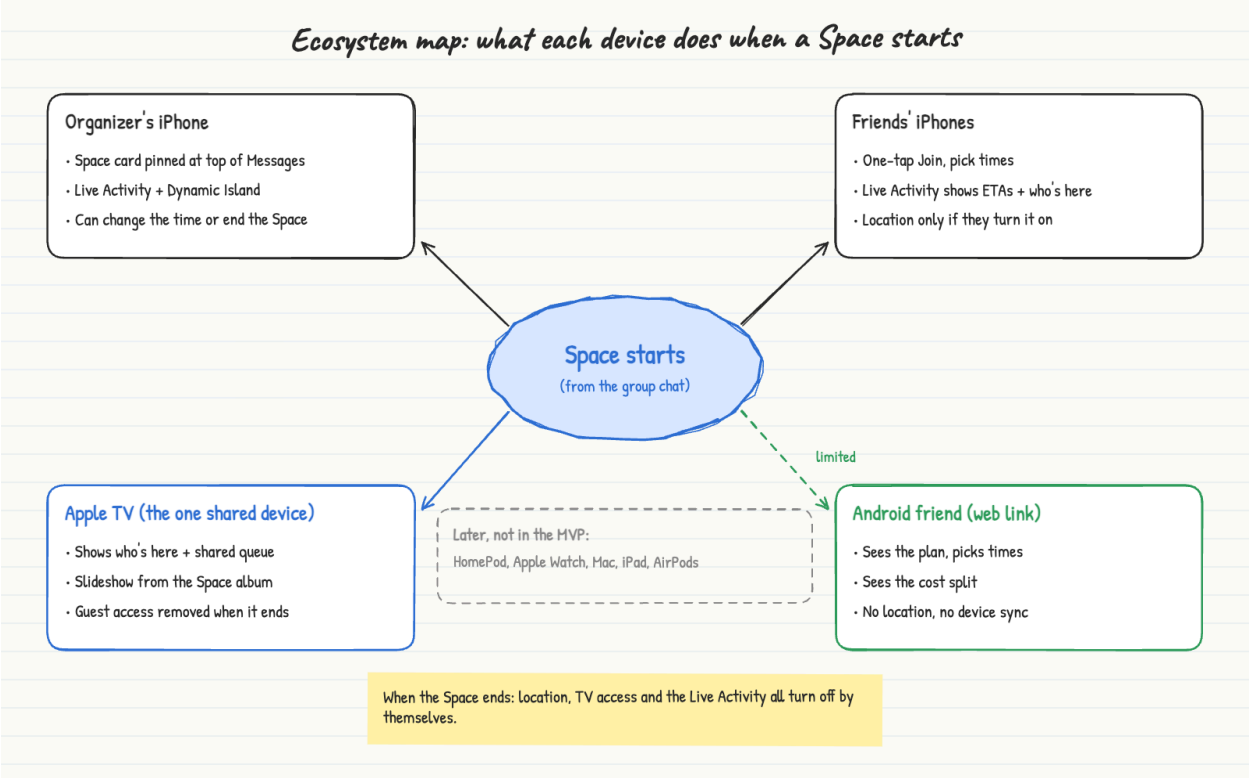
Where Spaces should live: we each sketched ideas for Messages, the Dynamic Island / Lock Screen, and Control Center. Messages makes the most sense for starting a space since everyone already plans in group chats, and the Dynamic Island is the best place to check on a live space. This lines up with our Create Space mockup.



Core screens: create, invite card, the live space, and the end summary. These are rough on purpose so we can test them before building anything high fidelity.



Ecosystem map: the MVP is just iPhone plus one shared device (Apple TV). Everything else waits until after we test the core flow.



Next steps for sketches: test these rough sketches with a few students first, then build the high-fidelity version in Figma using Apple's iOS design kit, and fully build just the one flow we'll demo (start, invite, join, end).

5. Validation Plan

This section defines how the proposed solution will be tested.

Validation method: Choose the smallest suitable test: prototype test, usability session, pilot, limited release, or other experiment.

Prototype test. First we'll do 3-4 quick follow-up interviews with people from our survey who left their contact info, to check if the during-hangout pain is real. Then we'll test the rough paper sketches (storyboard and core screens) with a few students, fix whatever confuses them, and only then build the one demo flow (start, invite, join, end) in Figma using Apple's iOS design kit.

Test participants / context: Specify who will test the MVP and under what conditions; reference the existing research persona or segment.

5-6 college students from our survey who have an iPhone. Mostly people like Maya (Social Coordinator) since they usually start the plans, plus a couple people like Jordan (Lowkey Joiner). At least one of them should have a friend on Android so we can test the web link. Each session is about 15-20 minutes on campus, and they walk through planning a real hangout they have coming up.

Evidence to collect: List observable behaviors or data that test the key assumption and success thresholds.

- Main metric (for a later pilot): repeat use, how many friend groups start another space within 30 days
- Whether testers can start a space and invite friends without help, and how many steps it takes compared to the group chat (goal: 3-4 steps down to 1)
- Whether testers can explain how Spaces is different from Apple Invites in their own words
- Guardrails: how many people turn off location sharing, how many spaces get ended early, and if anyone is confused about what's being shared
- From the follow-up interviews: whether people bring up a during-hangout pain on their own without us asking

Next-step rule: State what result means continue, iterate, pivot, or stop.

- Continue: at least 4 out of 6 testers finish the flow without help and say they'd use it for their next hangout, so we build the high-fidelity demo flow
- Iterate: testers finish but get confused by the invite card or what's being shared, so we fix those screens and test again
- Pivot: the follow-up interviews don't back the during-hangout pain, so Spaces focuses fully on the planning stage (availability, the plan, costs)

- Stop: testers don't see a difference between Spaces and group chats or Apple Invites

6. Stakeholders, Ownership, and Risks

Keep only people who need to make, approve, build, secure, operate, or support this MVP decision. Avoid maintaining both a stakeholder map and a separate stakeholder list with the same names.

Person / team	Role in this MVP	Decision or contribution needed	Owner / next action
Leadership (project lead)	Owns the MVP scope and keeps us on one space type and one demo flow	Final call on scope and the demo flow, turns in each sprint deliverable	Lock the scope with the team this week
Research Lead	Runs the follow-up interviews and the sketch tests	Tells us if the during-hangout pain is actually backed	Schedule 3-4 follow-up interviews from survey contacts
Design/UX Lead	Owns the storyboards, sketches, and the Figma build	Signs off on the core screens and where Spaces lives, builds the demo flow with the iOS design kit	Turn the paper screens into the Figma flow after testing
Engineering Lead/ Tech Lead	Checks what's actually doable (Live Activity, syncing, Apple TV, web view)	Flags battery and notification limits and what we can prototype	Write up how syncing and the auto-off would work
Strategy Lead	Owns the Apple Invites answer, the revenue framing, and the metrics	Ecosystem retention + accessory sales story, main metric and guardrails	Draft the "why not just Invites" slide
Program mentor	Reviews the MVP and gives feedback	Sign-off to move on to PRD & Strategy/GTM	Review this doc at the next lead meeting
Test participants (college students)	Try the sketches and the demo flow	Tell us what's confusing and if they'd actually use it	Recruit 5-6 from the survey contacts

Record only material risks that could affect the MVP test:

Risk	Likelihood / impact	Mitigation or test	Owner
Our research doesn't fully back the during-hangout part yet	Medium / High	3-4 follow-up interviews, and Spaces starts at the planning stage either way	Research Lead
"Isn't this just Apple Invites?"	High / High	Show that Spaces is live and changes how devices behave, and check if testers can explain the difference	Strategy Lead

People don't want to share their location	Medium / High	Location defaults to off, sharing ends with the space, and we track people turning it off as a guardrail	Design/UX Lead
Android friends feel left out	High / Medium	Limited web view for the plan, times, and cost split	Engineering Lead/ Tech Lead
Battery drain and too many notifications	Medium / Medium	Live Activity only updates when something changes, and notifications get bundled into one	Engineering Lead/ Tech Lead
Scope creep	Medium / Medium	One space type, iPhone + Apple TV only, and we fully build just the one demo flow	Leadership

7. Launch / Review Decision

MVP Review: ensure every group member agrees with contents in MVP

Member	**Yes/No**
Patrick Semler	Yes
Benjamin Aleman	Yes
Bhuvan Taliyakula	Yes
Diya Raj	Yes
Liam West	Yes